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Small shovel, firepan

4.4.5 Small shovel, firepan

References:

Hebrew מַחְתָּה (machtah) EXO 25:38, EXO 27:3, EXO 37:23, EXO 38:3, LEV 10:1, LEV 16:12, NUM 4:9, NUM 4:14, NUM 16:6, NUM 16:17, NUM 16:17, NUM 16:17, NUM 16:17, NUM 16:18, NUM 17:4, NUM 17:11, 1KI 7:50, 2KI 25:15, 2CH 4:22, JER 52:19

Description and usage:

A priest with a firepan tends the incense altar in the temple (Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The firepan was used to move or turn coals on the altar and to carry them to the altar of incense for other purposes (see 4.2.4 Incense altar<REALIA:4.2.4>).

Translation:

It has been suggested that the Hebrew word *machtah* also designated a special container for holding the holy fire while the altar was being cleaned or when the Tabernacle was being moved. This would make it a kind of "fire receptacle." Translators may also express this as "container for carrying away the hot ashes."

In some of the references listed above, the word *machtah* is associated with the burning of incense (LEV 10:1; NUM 16:6; NUM 16:17; NUM 16:18). Where a specific word for "censer" exists, it may be used in these passages, although care should be taken that the word does not suggest a modern censer. A more general word for "firepan" is also acceptable, since it seems that in most of the references listed above the word *machtah* refers to an implement that was used for carrying coals onto which incense was placed sometimes see also 4.2.4 Incense altar<REALIA:4.2.4> and 4.4.7 Censer<REALIA:4.4.7>.

A bronze firepan or incense shovel (Roman, late 1st–early 2nd c. CE) (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, MMA)In EXO 25:38; EXO 37:23; and NUM 4:9 the *machtah* is associated with the lampstand (see 4.3.4 Lampstand, menorah<REALIA:4.3.4>). Some versions still translate it "firepans" in those places (REB, NJPSV), while others say "trays" (RSV, GNT, NIV). In either case, it is not clear what purpose the *machtah* served in connection with the lampstand. The object described and illustrated here could have served multiple purposes.